



Language and Communication skills-I
BCA-I
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Introduction

It is a universally accepted phenomenon that “one who reads is the one who leads”. Reading has not received attention as much as it should have. Reading is receptive skill however, it demands plenty of effort from the reader. Reading refers to the ability to understand information presented in written form. If we understand the language, we can read and if we can read, we can comprehend. A good reader is not only a fast reader but also the one with complete understanding or information.

Reading Strategies

- ✓ Reading General Articles
- ✓ Reading Essays
- ✓ Reading Journal Articles

• Reading General Articles:

When we read general articles in newspaper, our aim is not to absorb the whole text but to get an idea about the topic and its application areas. The writer of the general articles also know this aim and hence they write in an easy to understand style. The following are a few tips for reading general articles:

- (1) Pay attention to the title, visuals and the introductory paragraph to know the topic.
- (2) Try to connect the ideas to understand the content. In order to create a dramatic impact, some authors may not present the ideas in a logical sequence.
- (3) Think how you can use the ideas from the articles you read in your everyday life.
- (4) Enjoy the language, subtle humor and the examples used by the author.

• Reading Essays:

Essays are generally written from the author's own point of view. As a part of the application process, anyone wishing to pursue higher studies is asked to write essays about their objectives. Similarly, students or professionals write such essays to get financial assistance for attending an event or as a part of recruitment tests. Only when we are able to read, understand essays in terms of their objective, language, style etc, we may able to write such essays. The more and more essays we read, the

better we will be able to enhance our knowledge. The following are few tips for reading essays:

- (1) Pay attention to the title, and the introductory paragraph to know the topic.
- (2) Identify the purpose.
- (3) Find out the author's point of view about the topic.
- (4) Infer the unstated assumption.
- (5) Decide whether to agree or disagree with author's definition of particular terms.
- (6) Analyze carefully the examples the author use.
- (7) Understand the structure.
- (8) Use the cue to understand the relationship between ideas.

- **Reading Journal Articles:**

The structure of a particular journal is generally determined by its editors. All journal articles have more or less similar structure beginning with an abstract, introduction, method, result, discussion, conclusion and references. While reading a journal article we need to pay attention to each of these parts. The following are few tips for reading journal articles:

- (1) Read the abstract first in order to get an overview about the whole article.
- (2) Read introduction to know the objectives of the article.
- (3) Know the findings of the author from the results section.
- (4) Read the discussion section to interpret the results.
- (5) Read the conclusion to understand the key issues related to the research paper.

Techniques of Reading

- ✓ Skimming and Scanning
- ✓ Non-verbal Signals
- ✓ Structure of the Text
- ✓ Structures of the Paragraphs
- ✓ Punctuation
- ✓ Author's view point
- ✓ Summarizing

(1) Skimming and Scanning:

- **Skimming:** To read quickly, without pausing to study the details is called skim reading or skimming. In fact it is the first step for an effective reading. In skimming, we do not comprehend the paragraph. We just go through the paragraph without paying attention to the meaning. Skimming takes place at very high rate speed. Here the reader's aim is to decide whether he or she should read the text fully and carefully. For example: while reading a newspaper, we just go through it without entering in detail. Such kind of reading is called skimming.
- **Scanning:** Scanning is a type of reading in which the reader searches for the specific information slowly and carefully. The reader turns the pages quickly where information is not significant. But once a person finds the appropriate page, he reads information on the page slowly to find a specific ideas or information.

For effective reading, both skimming and scanning are important. Scanning is soul of comprehensive reading because there we need to scan the paragraph to the answer of the question. In academic fields, scanning is very important to derive information.

(2) Non-verbal Signals:

The meaning of text is not only conveyed by means of words. All texts also contain non-verbal signs. Non-verbal signs may include style features, such as different fonts, bold print, underlining, or italics. The meaning of these style features can vary from one text to another. In one text italics may be used to emphasize a word, in another text italics can be used for subtitles.

(3) Structure of the Text:

Most texts start with a title or a subtitle. After that the reader can find the introduction, the body and a conclusion or summery. The introduction mostly informs the reader about what he can expect. The body consists of paragraphs. The paragraphs are linked in a logical manner. The conclusion sums up and puts the subject matter in the right way.

(4) Structure of Paragraphs:

A typical paragraph consists of three parts. The first sentence contains the topic sentence, which is the heart of the paragraph. The second part of the paragraph contains sentences which may include arguments, explanations, details, examples, etc. The last sentence of the paragraph is a summary of the paragraph or a linking sentence to the next paragraph.

(5) Punctuation:

Punctuation is based on grammar. For example; commas are often used to separate clauses. If the reader understand the meaning and usage of punctuation marks, it will be easier to understand grammatical structures. The reader can get the idea what the writer wants to convey through punctuation. For example; if the author puts something in brackets, it means that it is an addition to the sentence.

(6) Author's View Point:

While reading, the reader makes inference about the position of the author. Is the author neutral or he/she has an opinion? The author can add words like '_luckily' and '_unfortunately' to show approval or displeasure. The author can add so many words in the texts and that words convey author's point of views.

(7) Summarizing:

A summarization is a concise and clear statement of the sentence of a longer passage on a connected and readable shape. A summery must be accurate, clear and brief. The length of summary is about one-third of the text.

The following steps can be taken while summarizing a text:

- ✓ Familiarizing with the material
- ✓ Select important information
- ✓ Insert links between sentences and paragraphs
- ✓ Adjust the length of the summary

Techniques to Develop Reading Comprehension

- Cooperative Learning
 - Question generation
 - Understanding or Highlighting Important Content
 - Note Taking
 - Recalling and Retelling
 - Giving title to the Paragraphs
- **Cooperative Learning:** While using this strategy the readers work in groups. This is helpful as it promotes understanding, increase students confidence and reduce tension.
 - Each group summarizes and shares the content read
 - The shared summaries are compared
 - If any differences are observed during the process of sharing, the text is revisited and the differences are resolved.
 - **Question Generation:** Before starting to read, a reader should have a list of questions whose answers the reader tries to seek. The question may be of WH or yes / no type. This gives a clear direction to the reader. After reading, the reader should ensure that all their questions have been answered.
 - **Undertaking or Highlighting Important Content:** While reading, a reader should use pencil or pen. If it is a personal copy, a reader can have his/her own strategy to mark important points or information. He / she may underline a portion, draw asterisks, arrows, question mark or put certain content into brackets. One may also use highlighter but very carefully and not highlighting everything.
 - **Note Taking:** A student should prepare the visual map while reading. This will help him/her to decide if the content is understood or not. If the reader finds it difficult to take notes then it can be understood that he / she has difficulty in comprehending the text. After making notes, the reader should revisit them and verify that they make complete sense.
 - **Recalling and Retelling:** Having completed the reading, the reader should try to recall everything he/she has read and retell the same thing to someone who is

interested in the similar content. The process of retelling expects a reader to recall everything he /she read and organize them in an appropriate manner. Thus the habit of recalling and retelling something appropriately and effectively develops reading comprehension.

- **Giving Title to the Paragraphs:** The reader should try to give a title to each paragraph while reading. The title will reveal his / her understanding of the text and would him/her while referring to the same text at a later stage or while skimming the text at the time of exam to have a bird's eye view of the difficulty in the text.

There are several tips to improve comprehension skills which are as under:

- ✓ Read a variety of materials.
- ✓ Do not limit yourself to textbooks.
- ✓ Read a fairly long portion of the material.
- ✓ Try to read entire section or chapter.
- ✓ Mark out unknown or unfamiliar words as you read and find out the meaning later
- ✓ After reading, recall as much information as possible.
- ✓ Jot down point if you like it.
- ✓ Improve attention and concentration while reading.
- ✓ Promote critical thinking and evaluation of reading material.
- ✓ Do not skip the unknown information or words

Thus above tips would help the person to comprehend the message very effectively.